

Westhampton, MA Finance Committee Meeting Minutes

Westhampton Town Hall

March 18, 2026

Meeting Called to order at 7:05 pm

In attendance were FinCom members: Tad Weiss, Jeremy Durrin (Notetaker), Maureen Dempsey, Jon Albitz, Steve Holt, Jennifer Milikowsky, Scott Stanton.

Also in attendance were Douglas Finn, Chief of Police (David White), John Shaw, Marylou Burgess, Susan Bronstein of the Select Board

Motion to approve meeting minutes from previous meeting by Durrin, seconded by Dempsey.

VOTE: Approved: 5-0-0

Discussion on budget line items that have changed since the last meeting:

Hampshire Regional: Increase of town portion of their overall budget went from +\$40K to +\$56K (\$16,000 increase) after their meeting on the 16th in which they voted on the final budget that will be presented to towns. The overall school budget went up about \$160,000.

Elementary school – Newest budget estimate went up \$11K - but has not been voted on yet. It is a 1.3% increase from last year.

Vocational Tuition went down \$7k. This is due to Finn receiving actual costs and numbers of students enrolled in the Vocational system.

Account Salary and Accounting Expense lines have gone down by \$8,000 due to a new hire and no longer using an outside accounting firm. The new accountant has not started the position yet. Some discussion on whether there is enough money in the budget to cover training and overlap of the new and old accountants.

Insurance and bonds dropped from \$122K to \$111K which Finn received confirmation on.

Road Machinery Building: Discussion was had over road machinery building budget and whether additional money should be taken out because of the offset from solar covering the cost of the building's electricity. No changes were suggested without any further input from Superintendent Jablonski. Also discussed was whether **Road Machinery Fuel** funding for town vehicles could be underfunded based on the rapidly rising cost of diesel and propane. Again, no changes were recommended but recognition that this may be a future liability we will have to deal with at Town Meeting. Milikowsky read from Mass.gov webpages that fuel is considered part of the **Snow Removal** budget that can be legally overdrawn by municipalities.

After all these changes in budgeting, we reviewed where we stood in the deficit and it remained at just about exactly \$500,000.

Town Info Presentation on March 25th

Bronstein and Milikowsky went through the entire presentation to practice the slides and get feedback from the finance committee on what to add and change before the first info meeting next week.

Motion was made to recommend passage of the \$500,000 override by Durrin, seconded by Stanton.

VOTE: Approved: 6-0-1

Stanton made a motion that FinCom would recommend voting down the Hampshire Regional budget if the Override failed and we were forced to implement the Austerity Budget. Seconded by Albitz. [FinCom wanted to express our interest in the High School participating more fully in the Austerity Budget process. By voting down the High School budget we might find more shared pain when the time came to cutting town services and the Elementary School budget. Weiss reminded FinCom that \$100,000 in lower HS budgets for Westhampton would require more than \$700k in cuts to the HS budget, as we are roughly 14% of their budget.]

VOTE: Approved: 7-0-0

Motion to adjourn meeting made by Durrin seconded by Albitz (9:49pm)

VOTE: Approved: 7-0-0